

SORT

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KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Take everything off the counter and set it on the dining table, then let only three things back: what you cut on, what you cut with, and what you season with. The vitamins, the second cutting board, the bread bag and the pile of receipts find homes elsewhere or leave.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

STRAIGHTEN

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KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Put the board where you already stand without thinking, then build outward from it. Knives on a wall strip or in a block on your dominant side, oil and salt behind the board rather than beside it, mixing bowls in the cabinet directly underneath so you can reach one without turning around.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

SHINE

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KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Lift the toaster and the kettle instead of wiping around them, because crumbs collect under the appliance feet and never move. Run a damp cloth along the seam where the counter meets the backsplash, and shake the toaster crumb tray out over the bin.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

SAFETY

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KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Knives belong in a block, on a magnetic strip, or in a bladed sleeve in a drawer, never loose among the utensils and never blade-up in the drying rack. Keep the kettle and toaster cords off the sink side of the counter, where a wet hand meets them.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

STANDARDIZE

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KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

Mark the clear run so it is not a matter of opinion. A short strip of tape under the counter lip, or the outline of the board itself, tells everyone in the house where the work surface starts and that it stays empty.



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SUSTAIN

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KITCHEN

Primary Prep Counter

When you start the dishwasher, the board goes back down onto bare counter. If it will not sit flat, something has arrived that does not live here.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

SORT

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KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Empty the utensil crock into a box and cook for a week, returning to the crock only what your hand actually reaches for. The warped plastic turner, the corn holders, and the third pair of tongs are still in the box at the end of the week, which is your answer.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

STRAIGHTEN

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KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Arrange by the moment of need, not by shape. Oil, salt, and the turner within one reach of the burner, spices in a shallow drawer or tiered rack where you read the lids from above rather than shuffling jars, pans stored on the side you plate from.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

SHINE

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KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Lift the burner grates off and soak them while you wash the splash wall and the underside of the hood with dish soap. Take the hood filter out and run it through hot soapy water, because a saturated filter stops pulling steam and starts dripping it back down.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Turn every pan handle inward so it cannot catch a sleeve or a small hand reaching up. Keep the tea towel, the paper roll, and the oil bottle off the burner side of the hob, and know where the fire blanket or extinguisher is before a pan is smoking. If the hob burns gas, three things belong in this pass. Know where the shutoff ...



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

Photograph the hob and one step of surround in its ready state and tape the photo inside the nearest cabinet door, so ready is a picture anyone can match rather than a standard only you hold.



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KITCHEN

Cooking Zone

While the pan heats, the spice you just used goes back to the front of the rack and any utensil on the counter goes back in the crock.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Pull everything out from under the sink and line it up on the floor. Combine the three half-empty bottles of the same spray, bin what has separated or lost its label, and move out anything that is not dish, sink, or plumbing related, because that cabinet gets damp and is the wrong home for spare bulbs, paper goods, or vases.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Soap and brush live in a caddy you can lift with one wet hand, so wiping under them takes no planning. Dishwasher tablets go in a container beside the machine rather than across the room, and the towel gets a bar within reach of somebody already standing at the basin.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

The sponge is the dirtiest object in the room: wring it out and stand it on edge after every wash, and retire it the day it smells while dry. Scrub the drain flange, wipe the rubber seal all the way around the dishwasher door, and pull the dishwasher filter out and rinse it, because a filter that has never come out since the ...



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Never store bleach beside an ammonia or toilet cleaner under this sink, and never combine them in the basin; keep them apart, capped, and labels facing out. If small children live here or visit, this is the one kitchen cabinet that genuinely earns a latch.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

Write the empty-sink standard on a card taped inside the cabinet door: dishes in the machine or washed, basin wiped, brush standing, towel hung. A standard is the best way you know today, written down.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Sink and Dishwashing Zone

The last thing before the kitchen light goes off, the sink gets emptied and the basin gets wiped dry.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Upper Cabinet Zone

Count the mugs, then count the people who drink from them. The conference giveaway, the chipped one, and the one nobody ever chooses off the shelf come out first, because chips and crazed glaze are the easy calls and they shorten the argument about the rest.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Upper Cabinet Zone

Put dinner plates and everyday bowls at eye level on the side nearest the dishwasher or the table, glasses beside them, and send the serving platters and the punch bowl to the top shelf, where a step stool is an honest once-a-year cost.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Upper Cabinet Zone

Take each shelf completely empty before wiping, because the band of dust at the back is how you find out it has not been cleared in years. Wipe the underside of the cabinet nearest the hob, where a greasy film settles that you only see when you look at it from an angle.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Upper Cabinet Zone

Heavy and breakable do not belong above head height. The stack of casserole dishes or the cast iron lid stored overhead is the one that eventually comes down on somebody, so move that weight low. Use a real step stool, never a chair edge and never an open drawer front.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Upper Cabinet Zone

Label the shelf edge rather than the contents: plates, bowls, glasses, mugs. Then anyone emptying the dishwasher can put things away correctly without asking you where they go.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Upper Cabinet Zone

Emptying the dishwasher is the check. If a clean plate or mug has nowhere obvious to go, the shelf is over its limit and something on it is due to leave.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Empty the entire cabinet onto the floor, which is the only way you will ever find the third saucepan and the wok bought for one weekend. Keep what actually cooked something in the past year. Nonstick worn through to the metal in the middle is not a spare, it is finished, and it goes to metal recycling rather than to the back of ...



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Nest by size but cap any stack at three, with a cloth or a sheet of paper between coated surfaces. Lids stand in a rack or on a rail inside the door, and baking sheets go on edge in a divider so you stop lifting three to reach the fourth.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Wipe the shelf floor itself, where oil creeps down from pan bases and holds dust into a tacky film that resists a dry cloth. While everything is out, twist every pan handle and tighten any rivet or screw that moves.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Keep the cast iron and the full stockpot on the cabinet floor, never above waist height, and lift them from a squat rather than bending over the open door. If a stack slides when the door is closed hard, it will one day land on a foot, so build the stack so it survives a slam.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

Size the divider slots to your actual pans and write the pan on the front edge of each slot, so the wide skillet slot cannot quietly become the place lids get dropped.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Lower Cabinet and Cookware Zone

When the pans are dry, they go back into their named slots. A pan that lives on the hob overnight is telling you its slot is too hard to reach, so fix the slot.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Tip one drawer at a time onto a tea towel and put back only what you have used since the season changed. Two can openers means one leaves. The takeaway chopsticks, the rubber bands, the unlabelled key, and the loose batteries are not cooking tools and do not go back in.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Dividers go in before anything else, and you name the drawer before you fill it. Flatware nearest the dishwasher, cooking tools nearest the hob, measuring spoons and the scale beside the baking cupboard, and wraps in the drawer you can pull open while holding a dish in your other hand.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Lift the insert right out and tip the grit, because the crumbs that jam a drawer collect underneath the divider and in the runner track. Wipe both runners and check that the drawer closes flush again before you refill it.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

The peeler, the mandoline blade, and the loose paring knife are exactly what your fingers meet when you rummage without looking. Give every blade a sheath, a sleeve, or its own shallow tray at the front where you see it before you reach past it.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

Write the name inside each drawer front: flatware, cooking tools, wraps and bags, utility. The name is the rule, and anything that does not match the name does not go in that drawer.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

KITCHEN

Utensil and Utility Drawers

When you put the shopping away, the new roll of foil goes in on end, and anything that has migrated into the wrong drawer travels back to its own.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Refrigerator and Freezer

Work one shelf at a time so nothing sits out warming while you decide. Anything frozen past recognition and unlabelled goes, and every opened jar, sauce, and dressing gets judged against the date on its lid rather than by smell, because dressings and sauces go on smelling fine long after they should have gone.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Refrigerator and Freezer

Raw proteins go on the lowest shelf, where a leaking package cannot drip onto anything below it. Dairy goes inside the body of the fridge rather than in the door, where the temperature swings every time it opens. Produce goes in the drawers with the humidity slider actually set, and the eat-first bin goes at the front at eye ...



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Refrigerator and Freezer

Pull the crisper drawers right out and wash them in the sink, because the sticky ring under a drawer is where a forgotten cucumber ended. Vacuum the condenser coils at the back or underneath, and wipe the door gasket in its folds, since a gasket usually fails from grime long before it fails from age.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Refrigerator and Freezer

Raw meat sealed and stored below ready-to-eat food is nearly the whole of cross contamination prevention in one move. Keep the rear vents clear so the compartment actually holds its temperature, and put a cheap thermometer on the middle shelf so you know what the fridge is running at instead of assuming.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Refrigerator and Freezer

A roll of tape and a marker live on top of the fridge, and nothing goes in without a name and a date on the lid. If it is not named and dated, it is not stored, it is abandoned.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

Refrigerator and Freezer

Before you write the shopping list, the eat-first bin gets emptied of anything past, and the list gets written from the gaps that leaves.



SAFETY IS THE 4TH S

The standards that keep these zones

KITCHEN · PRIMARY PREP COUNTER

The clear run stays clear: one board, one knife block or strip, one seasoning within reach, and nothing parked on the work surface overnight.

When you press start on the dishwasher, the counter clears.

KITCHEN · COOKING ZONE

Oil, salt, and your turner within one reach of the burner, no more than six tools in the crock, handles turned in, and a clear landing space beside the hob at all times.

Every time you put a pan on to heat.

KITCHEN · SINK AND DISHWASHING ZONE

Empty sink, dry basin, one brush and one sponge standing, cleaners on one tray with the plumbing visible.

When the coffee brews in the morning, the sink gets checked and cleared.

KITCHEN · UPPER CABINET ZONE

Daily dishes between shoulder and eye height, one category per stack, top shelf reserved for what you use less than monthly.

Every time the clean dishwasher gets emptied.

KITCHEN · LOWER CABINET AND COOKWARE ZONE

Stacks capped at three, lids racked, heaviest pieces on the cabinet floor, and the two nightly pans at the front.

When the pans come off the drying rack.

KITCHEN · UTENSIL AND UTILITY DRAWERS

One category per drawer, named inside the front edge, blades sheathed, and every drawer closing with one push.

When you put the shopping away.

KITCHEN · REFRIGERATOR AND FREEZER

Raw meat low and sealed, dated containers at eye level, one eat-first bin at the front, and the rear vents clear.

On the way to write the shopping list, before the grocery run.